

Justin Crawford — Year-to-Date Read

Phillies Offense · UC #35 · [uc-pos-011-crawford-ytd-001](#) · [dp_uc34](#) · data through **13 Aug 2026** · verification **127/127 PASS**

Read this first. The premise holds directionally and the mechanism is not what the premise assumes. Crawford's results *are* better since mid-June — wOBA .276 → .321, BA .231 → .312, OBP .289 → .345. But **on-base gains came entirely from batting average; his walk rate fell** (6.6% → 4.6%). **His power fell** (ISO .097 → .072, zero home runs after 15 June). **His ground-ball rate and launch angle did not meaningfully change** — the two indicators the development path has always flagged. And **the Derek Hill platoon hypothesis is falsified over the window it was proposed for**: Crawford's share of plate appearances against left-handers is 15.0% after Hill arrived versus 15.3% before. The shielding is real, but it starts in **August**, not in June. What did durably improve is **contact** — strikeout rate 20.9% → 15.2%.

1 · The premise, tested

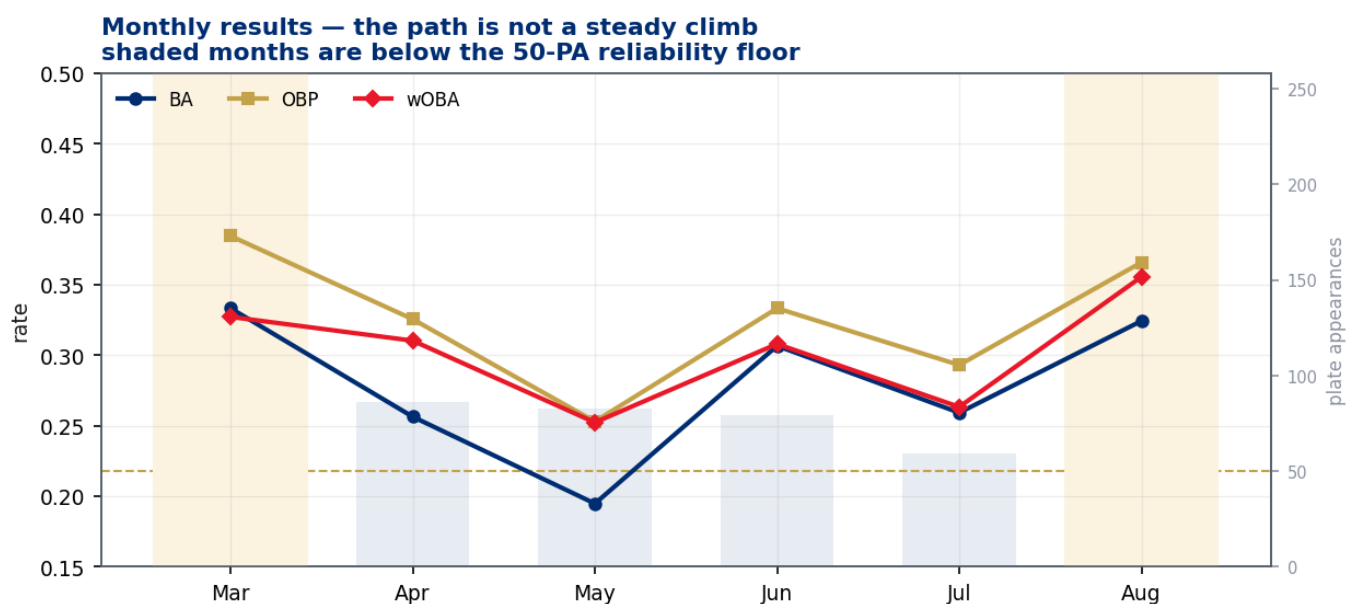
The submitted use case makes four testable assertions. Each is answered against the governed monthly panel before any explanation is attempted.

#	Assertion as submitted	Verdict	Evidence
1	"Since roughly mid-June he has been hitting the ball much better"	Directionally supported, mechanism differs	wOBA .276 → .321 across 15 Jun. But <i>hitting the ball</i> barely moved — mean launch angle 2.28° → 2.22°, hard-hit rate .338 → .358, ISO down .097 → .072
2	"His batting average slowly climbing up"	Supported — but not slowly, and not monotonic	.231 → .312. Monthly wOBA path is .327 / .310 / .252 / .308 / .263 / .356. July is a relapse month , not a step on a ramp
3	"His OBP bouncing back"	Supported, with a caveat that matters	.289 → .345. All of it is batting average. Walk rate fell 6.6% → 4.6%. This is a hit-dependent OBP, not a plate-discipline OBP
4	"His wOBA coming up"	Supported	.276 → .321. Above the .316 league wOBA baseline for 2026, for the first time in his career

Season line, through 13 August

PA	AB	H	HR	BB	K	BA	OBP	SLG	OPS	ISO	wOBA	BABIP
362	333	88	2	21	67	.264	.312	.351	.663	.087	.295	.323

109 games, 1,323 pitches. Left-handed. Regular season plus postseason; Spring and Exhibition excluded.



The breakpoint is not robust — and this matters

The "mid-June" boundary was supplied by the requester, and the finding is sensitive to it. Every candidate breakpoint was priced, per the `uc-pos-008` both-framings rule:

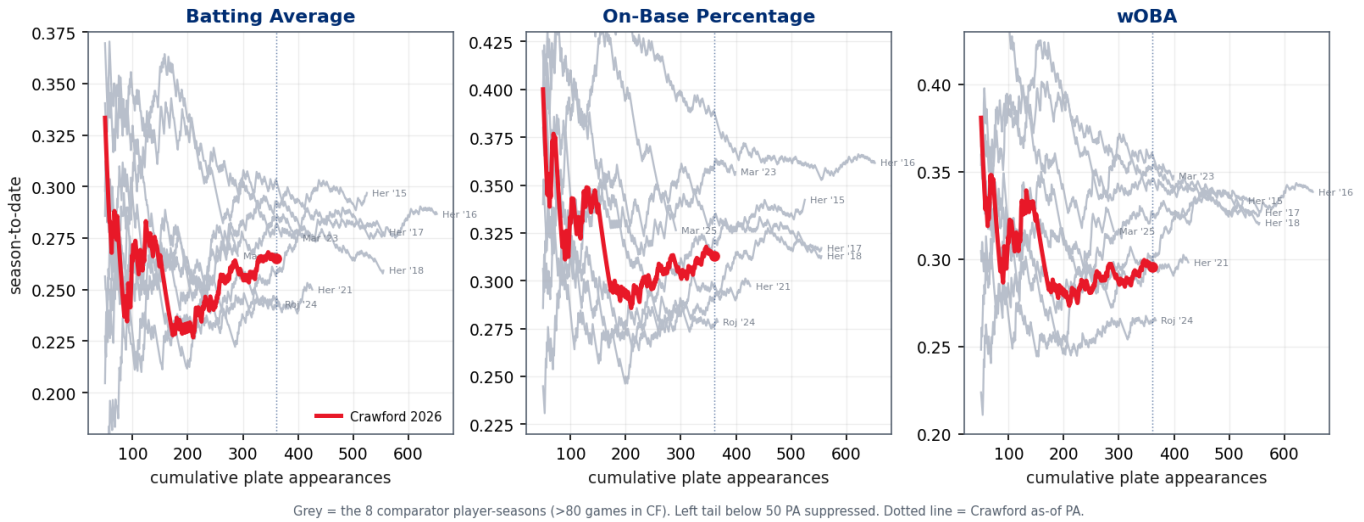
Breakpoint	Pre PA	Pre wOBA	Post PA	Post wOBA	Δ
1 May	99	.313	263	.288	−.025
15 May	135	.332	227	.272	−.060
1 Jun	182	.285	180	.304	+.019
8 Jun	199	.280	163	.313	+.034
15 Jun (as submitted)	211	.276	151	.321	+.045
22 Jun	230	.285	132	.312	+.026
1 Jul	261	.292	101	.302	+.010
15 Jul	287	.296	75	.288	−.008
1 Aug	320	.287	42	.356	+.069

A mid-May breakpoint reverses the sign entirely. The improvement is real at the 15 June boundary, but the boundary was chosen after seeing the outcome. Everything downstream of it is reported as **descriptive**, not inferential. The strongest available split is 1 August — which is 42 plate appearances, **below the 50-PA reliability floor**.

2 · Context — Crawford against Phillies centre field, Statcast era

The comparison population is **Phillies primary centre fielders since 2015**: any player-season with more than 80 games in centre, restricted to games in which he actually played the position. Eight comparator seasons qualify. Crawford's 110 centre-field games in 2026 place him squarely in the group.

Justin Crawford 2026 vs Phillies primary centre fielders, Statcast era



The shape of the red line is the most honest summary of the season. Through roughly 200 plate appearances Crawford was **the worst of the nine seasons on all three measures**. From plate appearance 200 forward he climbs while most of the grey lines flatten — the visual signature of a genuine mid-season turn. He has climbed from last to mid-pack, not from mid-pack to good.

At matched volume — 361 plate appearances

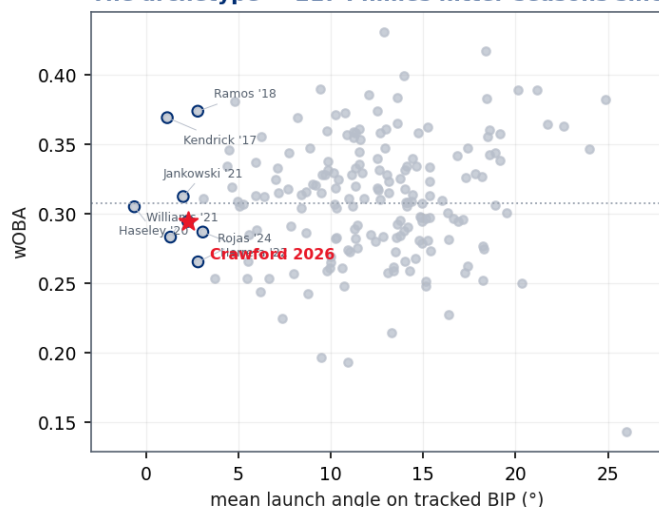
Rank	Season	BA	OBP	wOBA
1	Herrera 2016	.303	.388	.360
2	Marsh 2023	.284	.361	.353
3	Herrera 2018	.282	.334	.346
4	Herrera 2015	.291	.320	.325
5	Herrera 2017	.259	.291	.301
6	Herrera 2021	.246	.298	.300
7	Crawford 2026	.265	.313	.295
8	Rojas 2024	.243	.278	.265

Seventh of eight in wOBA, fourth of eight in OBP. The gap between those two ranks is the season in miniature: he gets on base at a respectable rate for the group and does nothing once there. He is ahead of only Johan Rojas 2024 — the closest stylistic comparison in the set, and not the comparison anyone wants.

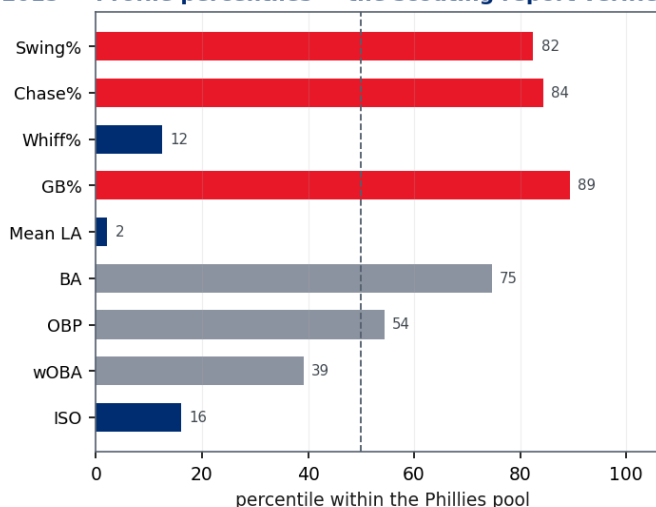
3 · The profile — the scouting report verifies, including the parts nobody wants

Crawford is benchmarked against **217 Phillies hitter-seasons since 2015** (98 players, ≥ 50 PA). Launch-angle percentiles use the 186 seasons clearing 50 tracked balls in play.

The archetype — 217 Phillies hitter-seasons since 2015



Profile percentiles — the scouting report verifies



Trait	Crawford	Pool median	Percentile	Reads as
Swing rate	.537	.486	82nd	High-swing — confirmed
Chase rate	.377	.301	84th	High-chase — confirmed
Whiff rate	.186	.262	12th	Low-whiff — confirmed, and it is his best skill
Ground-ball rate	.565	.445	89th	The knock — confirmed
Mean launch angle	2.26°	12.51°	2nd	The knock — confirmed, and it is extreme
BABIP	.323	.296	74th	Speed shows up here
BA	.264	.245	75th	
OBP	.312	.307	54th	
ISO	.087	.150	16th	
wOBA	.295	.308	39th	The profile's net value

He swings a lot, he chases a lot, and he almost never misses. That combination is unusual and it is genuinely valuable — a 12th-percentile whiff rate on an 84th-percentile chase rate means he is putting bat on balls other hitters swing through entirely. It is also precisely why the launch-angle number is what it is: making contact with pitches you should not have swung at produces ground balls.

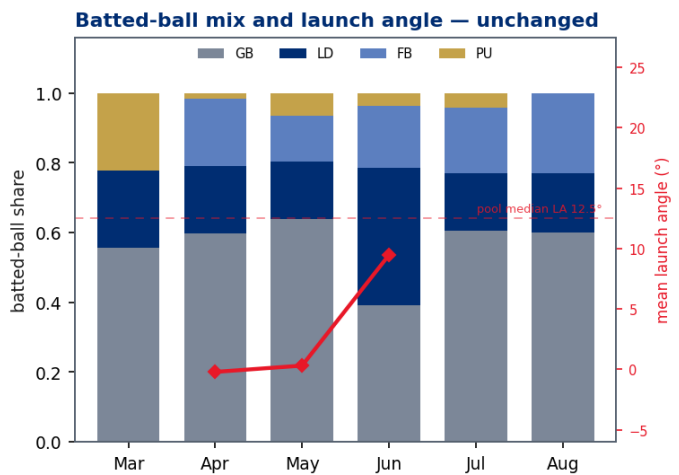
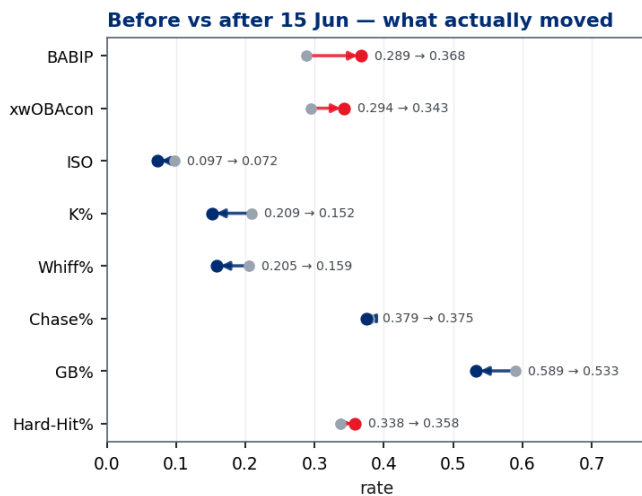
The archetype, and what it has historically been worth

The nine lowest launch angles among Phillies hitter-seasons since 2015:

Player-season	PA	Mean LA	GB%	BA	ISO	wOBA
Haseley 2020	91	−0.6°	.561	.278	.063	.305
Kendrick 2017	156	1.1°	.571	.340	.113	.369
Williams 2021	108	1.3°	.600	.245	.071	.283
Jankowski 2021	153	2.0°	.538	.252	.099	.312
Crawford 2026	362	2.3°	.565	.264	.087	.295
Ramos 2018	100	2.8°	.625	.337	.146	.374
Rojas 2024	369	2.8°	.591	.242	.079	.265
Herrera 2022	197	3.1°	.576	.238	.141	.287
Revere 2015	388	3.1°	.596	.298	.077	.311

Two observations. First, **Crawford's is the largest sample in the cohort** — most of these are partial seasons or bench roles; his is a full-time job. Second, the only cohort members who cleared a .350 wOBA (Kendrick, Ramos) did it on 100–156 plate appearances and with meaningfully more power. **Ben Revere 2015 is the honest ceiling case for this batted-ball profile over a full season: .298/.077/.311.**

4 · What actually changed — and what did not



Metric	Before 15 Jun	From 15 Jun	Read
Plate appearances	211	151	
BABIP	.289	.368	+79 points. The single largest mover in the dataset
xwOBA on contact	.294	.343	Contact quality improved — but by less than results did
Strikeout rate	.209	.152	The most durable improvement
Whiff rate	.205	.159	Confirms the K-rate move is a contact skill, not luck
Chase rate	.379	.375	Unchanged. He did not become more selective
Swing rate	.523	.559	He became <i>more</i> aggressive
Walk rate	.066	.046	Fell
ISO	.097	.072	Fell. Zero home runs after 15 June
Ground-ball rate	.589	.533	Down 5.6 pts — real but modest
Mean launch angle	2.28°	2.22°	Unchanged
Hard-hit rate	.338	.358	Marginal

The ground-ball detail that settles it

Window	Ground balls	GB hits	GB BA	Mean EV on GB	GB xBA	GB hits ≤ 90 ft
Before 15 Jun	89	23	.258	84.9 mph	.282	18
From 15 Jun	64	20	.312	80.4 mph	.275	17

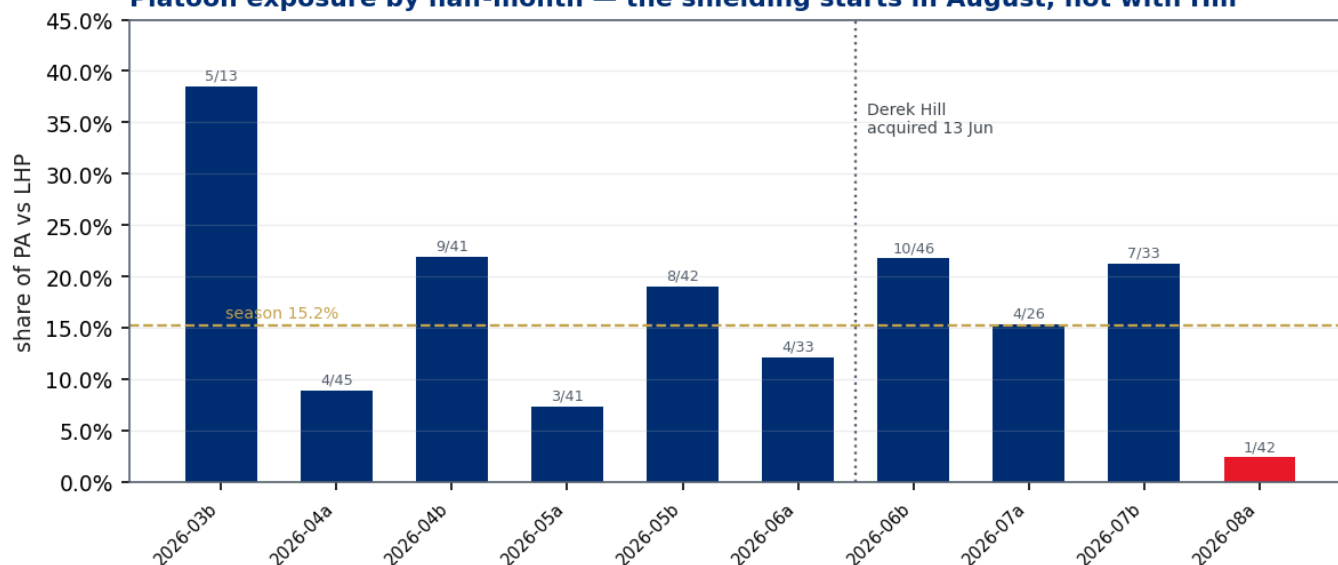
He is hitting ground balls *softer* and getting *more* hits on them. Expected batting average on those grounders actually fell (.282 → .275) while actual batting average rose 54 points. Thirty-five of his 43 ground-ball hits on the season travelled 90 feet or less. This is legs, placement and defensive positioning — not improved contact. It is a genuine skill, and it is a **volatile** one.

The honest decomposition. Roughly speaking: strikeout rate is the improvement he earned and can hold; BABIP is the improvement he is currently being given. xwOBAcon rose 49 points while BABIP rose 79 — the gap is the part most likely to regress.

5 · Platoon — the Derek Hill hypothesis, tested and falsified as posed

Derek Hill's first Phillies game was **13 June 2026** — two days before the requester's breakpoint, which makes the hypothesis a serious one. It does not survive contact with the exposure data.

Platoon exposure by half-month — the shielding starts in August, not with Hill



Window	PA vs LHP	PA vs RHP	LHP share
Before 13 Jun (pre-Hill)	32	177	15.3%
From 13 Jun (post-Hill)	23	130	15.0%

Direct standardisation — holding the post-Hill within-split rates fixed and re-weighting them to the pre-Hill platoon mix — puts the entire mix effect at **−0.0001 on BA, −0.0001 on OBP, and −0.0000 on wOBA**. The platoon mix explains none of the improvement across the window the hypothesis was proposed for.

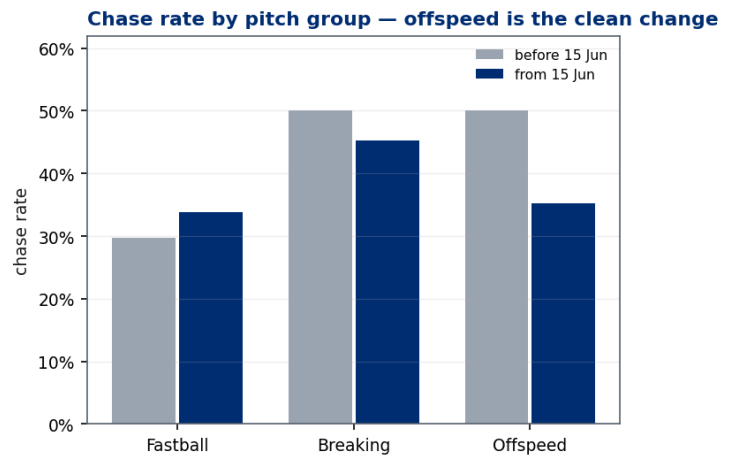
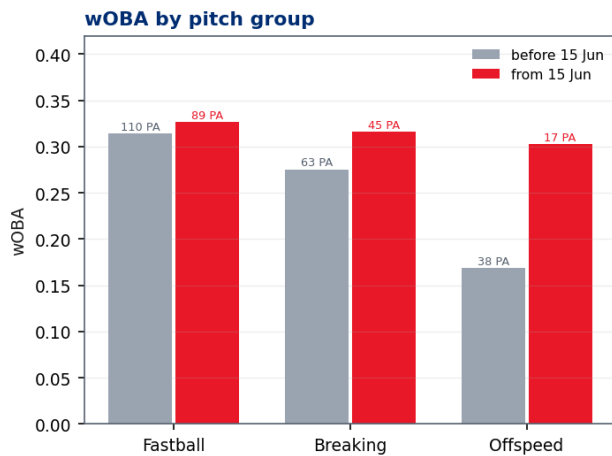
But the instinct behind the question is correct, and the timing is different. August tells another story:

Half-month	PA vs LHP	Total PA	LHP share
2026-06b	10	46	21.7%
2026-07a	4	26	15.4%
2026-07b	7	33	21.2%
2026-08a	1	42	2.4%

The shielding is real and it is severe — but it begins roughly seven weeks after Hill arrived, which points at a deliberate August decision rather than a roster-driven one. **The practical consequence: August's .356 wOBA is very nearly a pure right-handed-pitching sample and must not be read as a step forward in overall quality.** It is also 42 plate appearances, below the reliability floor.

One further wrinkle worth flagging, precisely because it cuts against the shielding decision: Crawford's line against left-handers actually *improved* after 13 June (.143/.250/.143 → .333/.391/.333). That is 23 plate appearances and proves nothing — but it is the opposite of the pattern that would justify a platoon, and it deserves a larger sample before the shielding hardens into policy.

6 · Pitch types — where he is beating people, and where he is not



Pitch group	Window	Pitches	PA	BA	SLG	wOBA	K%	Whiff%	Chase%
Fastball	before	516	110	.263	.364	.314	.209	.213	.298
Fastball	from 15 Jun	335	89	.308	.372	.327	.157	.142	.338
Breaking	before	180	63	.220	.356	.275	.238	.188	.500
Breaking	from 15 Jun	138	45	.318	.432	.316	.178	.173	.453
Offspeed	before	97	38	.162	.189	.168	.158	.197	.500
Offspeed	from 15 Jun	57	17	.312	.312	.303	.059	.226	.353

The offspeed change is the cleanest approach signal in the dataset — chase against changeups and splitters fell from 50.0% to 35.3%, and the wOBA against them went from .168 to .303. It is also **17 plate appearances**, far below any floor. Treat it as a hypothesis to re-test in September, not a finding.

Season, by pitch type (≥ 40 pitches)

Pitch	Pitches	PA	BA	SLG	wOBA	K%	Whiff%	Chase%
Four-seam (FF)	533	113	.297	.376	.321	.221	.191	.274
Sinker (SI)	230	63	.291	.400	.350	.175	.136	.349
Slider (SL)	132	43	.262	.357	.261	.140	.080	.479
Changeup (CH)	112	41	.231	.256	.238	.171	.224	.480
Curveball (CU)	89	31	.200	.333	.241	.290	.222	.489
Cutter (FC)	88	23	.190	.238	.231	.043	.240	.417
Sweeper (ST)	76	26	.320	.520	.372	.308	.289	.550
Splitter (FS)	41	14	.143	.143	.127	.000	.160	.375

Call-outs for the advance group:

- **Sinkers are his best pitch** (.350 wOBA, 13.6% whiff). A sinker to a hitter with a 2° average launch angle should be a ground ball, and often is — but he beats enough of them out that the pitch is not working.

- **Sliders: he barely misses them (8.0% whiff, the lowest of any pitch) but chases them 47.9% of the time.** The resulting contact is weak. This is the pitch that most rewards throwing it out of the zone.
- **Splitters and cutters are the two genuine holes** — .127 and .231 wOBA. He has never struck out against a splitter (0 K in 14 PA) and he has not hit one either.
- **Sweepers are a warning** — .372 wOBA against, but on a 28.9% whiff rate and a 55.0% chase rate. The results are ahead of the process; this is the pitch most likely to turn on him.

7 • Count leverage — the one clear regression

Window	Count state	PA	BA	OBP	SLG	wOBA	K%
Before 15 Jun	Ahead	26	.429	.538	.762	.545	—
Before 15 Jun	Even/behind	72	.239	.250	.338	.256	—
Before 15 Jun	Two strikes	113	.184	.257	.233	.228	.389
From 15 Jun	Ahead	24	.300	.391	.350	.340	—
From 15 Jun	Even/behind	57	.434	.418	.528	.405	—
From 15 Jun	Two strikes	70	.215	.271	.277	.248	.329

Two-strike survival improved (K rate 38.9% → 32.9%), which is consistent with the whiff-rate move. But **his production when ahead in the count collapsed** — .545 wOBA to .340. He is doing more damage in neutral counts and less in the counts where a hitter should be hunting. Combined with a first-pitch swing rate that rose from 33.6% to 43.0%, the picture is a hitter who has become *more* aggressive, not more selective, and is currently being rewarded for it by ball-in-play luck.

8 • What this means

For the hitting coach. The contact gains are real and worth reinforcing: whiff rate down 4.6 points, strikeout rate down 5.7. The thing to *not* reinforce is the aggression — chase rate is flat at 37.5%, first-pitch swing rate is up 9 points, and production in hitter's counts fell by 200 points of wOBA. The single highest-value target remains launch angle: at 2.3° he sits in the 2nd percentile of Phillies hitter-seasons since 2015, and nothing in this window moved it. Ground-ball rate fell 5.6 points; average launch angle fell 0.06°.

For the manager. The improvement is real and it is smaller than it looks. Two-thirds of the wOBA gain traces to a 79-point BABIP jump on *softer* contact, against a 49-point rise in expected value on contact. The August line is 42 plate appearances against one left-hander. If the platoon shielding is deliberate, note that his production against left-handers has been better, not worse, since Hill arrived — on a sample too small to act on, which is itself the argument for giving him the plate appearances that would settle it.

For the player-development group. The developmental question is unchanged by this season. He has proven the contact skill translates — 12th-percentile whiff rate as a rookie is a genuine major-league tool. He has not proven the batted-ball profile can support a major-league regular, and the honest comparison set says a full season of this profile is worth roughly a .295–.315 wOBA. **The gap between "he is figuring it out" and "he is a good major-league hitter" is entirely launch angle**, and it is the same gap the reports flagged three years ago.

For the analytics group. Re-run after 31 August. The two signals to watch are (1) whether BABIP holds above .330 as the sample grows — it should not, and the size of the fall is the size of the correction to this report — and (2) whether launch angle moves at all. Everything else is downstream of those two.

Governance: `uc-pos-011-crawford-ytd-001` · `dp_uc34` · Phillies Offense value stream · sensitivity Internal · 127/127 independent verification assertions PASS · six defects in the governed KPI kernel reported in `05_quality_certification.md` (five inherited, one new) · restricted from external and media distribution · any figure quoted after 13 Aug 2026 must state the as-of date.